

JOHN W. BARRY

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Rice University
6100 Main Street MS 531
Houston, TX 77005

Email: john.w.barry@rice.edu
Office: (+1) 713-348-6242
Mobile: (+1) 346-228-2292
Web: <https://johnwbarry.info/>

ACADEMIC EMPLOYMENT

Rice University	Houston, TX
Assistant Professor of Finance	2024-

EDUCATION

Duke University, Fuqua School of Business	Durham, NC
PhD, Finance	2018-2024
Barcelona School of Economics	Barcelona, Spain
MS, International Trade, Finance and Development (ITFD)	2015-2016
Trinity College Dublin	Dublin, Ireland
BA, Philosophy, Politics, Economics & Sociology (PPES)	2009-2013

WORKING PAPERS

Shareholder Voice and Executive Compensation

Job market paper (December 2024) [Latest version, SSRN](#)

I estimate a model of CEO compensation with non-binding shareholder approval votes (Say-on-Pay). The Board sets compensation and (relative to shareholders) may prefer high total pay; shareholders can fail the vote and punish the Board for high pay. Failed votes are perceived as costly by the Board and shareholders: Say-on-Pay resembles a costly punishment mechanism, raising firm value by 2.4% on average, despite only 7% of votes failing. I analyze a counterfactual binding vote: failure binds pay to prior levels, which may not reflect current information about CEO ability. The failure rate falls, pay levels increase and firm value decreases.

Human Capital, Competition and Mobility in the Managerial Labor Market

with Noah Lyman and Lin Zhao (December 2024)

We estimate a search model of managerial careers to quantify the relative importance of human capital accumulation (both general and firm-specific), managerial bargaining power, and imperfect labor market competition in shaping compensation and mobility in the market for US corporate executives. The composition of human capital is career-dependent and varies widely across managers: over tenure, firm-specific capital is the greatest driver of wage growth, whereas over experience in the labor market, job search and competition dominate. Firm-specific capital can help explain the high rate of internal CEO hires and low observed cross-firm CEO mobility. We further show that labor market competition (relative to pure bargaining power) makes up the majority of realized CEO surplus capture, and that firm-specific human capital positively interacts with competition in determining CEOs' shares of rents because it raises the match-specific quality between the firm and manager.

Sacred Hurdle Rates and Bargaining Power

with Bruce Carlin, Alan Crane and John Graham (December 2024) [SSRN](#)

Earlier version: Project Development with Delegated Bargaining: The Role of Elevated Hurdle Rates

CFOs report using elevated hurdle rates that average 6.6 percentage points above the cost of capital. Managers take elevated hurdles as given (consider them sacred), and we show that negotiating to earn an elevated required return conveys a bargaining advantage over counterparties in project development and M&A. This benefit can exceed the opportunity cost of forgone projects, preserving firm value. Consistent with our model, bidders' elevated hurdle rates in M&A deals associate with higher surplus capture ex post; in CFO survey data, hurdle rate buffers negatively relate to ex ante bargaining power, and realized returns cluster just above elevated hurdle rates.

PUBLICATIONS

Corporate Flexibility in a Time of Crisis

with Murillo Campello, John Graham and Yueran Ma (June 2022)

[Journal of Financial Economics](#)

CONFERENCES AND SEMINARS

- 2025:** Southwestern Finance Conference[†], ITAM Finance Conference[†], Tilburg University[†], Univ. Amsterdam[†]
- 2024:** Toulouse School of Economics, CEMFI, Cornell University, Notre Dame University, Rice University, Ohio State University, UMass Amherst, MIT Sloan, Boston College, University of Maryland, Vanderbilt University, UVA Darden, MFA, Eastern Finance, Aarhus Strategic Interactions Workshop, Lone Star Finance Symposium, UTD Finance Conference
- 2023:** AFA, LBS TADC, Inter-Finance PhD Seminar, Duke IO lunch, Fuqua, Olin Finance Conference PhD Poster Session, Boca Finance Conference
- 2020-2022:** AFA, ITAM Finance Conference, Fuqua (×3) [†] = scheduled

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor	Rice University
Advanced Corporate Finance (Undergraduate)	2025-
Advanced Corporate Finance (MBA)	2025-
Head Teaching Assistant	Duke University
Corporate Finance (MBA)	2019-2023
Empirical Methods in Corporate Finance (PhD)	2019-2023
Pre-PhD	International House Dublin & Huelva
English Teacher	2013-2015

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Python, Julia, R, SQL, Stata, SAS, Git, SLURM

PROFESSIONAL SERVICES

Referee: American Economic Review: Insights, Journal of Human Capital, Management Science, Financial Management, Journal of Corporate Finance